Tired Zverev Is Proud of His Shanghai Run

From: BBC Tennis Mined: 2026-10-18 3 min read

German tennis star Alexander Zverev made it to the **semifinals** of the Shanghai Masters. Then he lost. Afterward, he said he had "**overachieved**," or done better than expected, because he was so tired.

Zverev is **ranked** number two in the world. He has played many **tournaments** in a row, including the US Open and the Laver Cup, with little time to rest. He said he came to Shanghai a bit hurt and tired.

In the semifinal, Zverev won the first set against Davidovich Fokina. But his **opponent** came back and won the deciding third set.

"We're all human beings, even the best players in the world," Zverev said.

It has still been a great year for him. He won the French Open in June and the US Open in September. He will also finish the year as world number one, the first German man to do so.

Davidovich Fokina will play fellow Spaniard Rafael Jodar in the final on Sunday.

Word Treasure

semifinals -- The round of a tournament just before the final.
overachieved -- Did better than expected.
ranked -- Given a place on a list of the best players.
tournaments -- Competitions with many players and matches.
opponent -- The person you play against in a game.

Background you need

Tennis players travel the world to play in tournaments, and they earn a ranking based on how well they do.

The French Open and the US Open are two of the biggest tennis tournaments.

A tennis match is split into sets, and the player who wins the most sets wins the match.

Break it down

WHO: German tennis star Alexander Zverev
WHAT: He lost in the semifinals but said he overachieved
WHERE: The Shanghai Masters tennis tournament
WHY: He was tired and a bit hurt after playing many tournaments in a row

Why it matters

Even top athletes get tired, which is a reminder that rest matters for everyone.

Test what you remember

1. What country is Alexander Zverev from?

- (A) China
- (B) Germany
- (C) Spain
- (D) Australia

2. Which tournament was he playing in?

- (A) Wimbledon
- (B) The Shanghai Masters
- (C) The World Cup
- (D) The Olympics

3. Why did Zverev say he overachieved?

- (A) Because he won the trophy
- (B) Because he was so tired
- (C) Because he had a new racket
- (D) Because it rained

4. Who beat Zverev in the semifinal?

- (A) Rafael Jodar
- (B) A player from Shanghai
- (C) Davidovich Fokina
- (D) Alex de Minaur

5. Which big titles did Zverev win this year?

- (A) The French Open and the US Open
- (B) None
- (C) Wimbledon and the Olympics
- (D) Only the Shanghai Masters

6. What will Zverev be at the end of the year?

- (A) Retired
- (B) A coach
- (C) World number ten
- (D) World number one

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Alexander Zverev: Says he overachieved because he played so much tennis and was tired.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):